

# Psalms 88

## *The Darkest Lament*

I am counted with them that go down into the pit  
KJV · Standalone study handout

### 1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 O LORD God of my salvation, I have cried day and night before thee:
- 2 Let my prayer come before thee: incline thine ear unto my cry;
- 3 For my soul is full of troubles: and my life draweth nigh unto the grave.
- 4 I am counted with them that go down into the pit: I am as a man that hath no strength:
- 5 Free among the dead, like the slain that lie in the grave, whom thou rememberest no more: and they are cut off from thy hand.
- 6 Thou hast laid me in the lowest pit, in darkness, in the deeps.
- 7 Thy wrath lieth hard upon me, and thou hast afflicted me with all thy waves. Selah.
- 8 Thou hast put away mine acquaintance far from me; thou hast made me an abomination unto them: I am shut up, and I cannot come forth.
- 9 Mine eye mourneth by reason of affliction: LORD, I have called daily upon thee, I have stretched out my hands unto thee.
- 10 Wilt thou shew wonders to the dead? shall the dead arise and praise thee? Selah.
- 11 Shall thy lovingkindness be declared in the grave? or thy faithfulness in destruction?
- 12 Shall thy wonders be known in the dark? and thy righteousness in the land of forgetfulness?
- 13 But unto thee have I cried, O LORD; and in the morning shall my prayer prevent thee.
- 14 LORD, why castest thou off my soul? why hidest thou thy face from me?
- 15 I am afflicted and ready to die from my youth up: while I suffer thy terrors I am distracted.
- 16 Thy fierce wrath goeth over me; thy terrors have cut me off.
- 17 They came round about me daily like water; they compassed me about together.
- 18 Lover and friend hast thou put far from me, and mine acquaintance into darkness.

### 2 · CONTEXT

Unlike almost every other psalm, Psalm 88 ends without a turn toward praise, resolution, or renewed hope—it closes in darkness, with the psalmist describing himself as surrounded by companions only in gloom. Attributed to Heman the Ezrahite, it gives voice to prolonged affliction, isolation, and the felt absence of God without offering an emotional resolution. Henry treats this psalm as proof that Scripture makes room for suffering that does not resolve on cue, and that even unrelieved lament is legitimate prayer.

### 3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

*The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.*

#### Verse 1-3

The opening address—'God of my salvation'—already holds tension between the psalmist's confessed faith and his actual experience: he has cried day and night, yet his soul is full of trouble and his life draws near the grave.

#### Verse 4-7

The imagery intensifies into near-death description: counted among those who go down to the pit, like the slain lying in the grave, forgotten and cut off from God's hand, laid in the lowest darkness and depths, God's wrath and waves pressing down on him.

#### Verse 8-9

Isolation compounds the suffering: acquaintances are put far away, he has become repulsive to them, shut in with no way out. His eyes are worn out with grief, yet he continues to stretch out his hands to God daily despite receiving no visible response.

#### Verse 10-12

A series of rhetorical questions presses the crisis theologically: will God show wonders to the dead, can the dead rise and praise Him, is His faithfulness declared in destruction or the grave, are His righteousness and wonders known in darkness and the land of forgetfulness? The implied answer underscores the urgency of being helped now, while still alive.

#### Verse 13-18

Morning prayer continues even without relief: why does God cast off his soul and hide His face? He has suffered since youth, God's terrors have cut him off, and his closest companions and friends have been replaced entirely by darkness. The psalm's final word, remarkably, is simply 'darkness'—no resolution is offered.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

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Meaning.

Scripture includes at least one prayer that ends without relief, resolution, or a turn to praise—validating that some suffering does not resolve on any predictable timeline, and that continuing to pray into unrelieved darkness is itself a legitimate, even faithful, act. The psalmist's persistence in crying out daily, despite receiving no answer, models faith that endures without requiring an immediate emotional payoff.

Application for life today.

If you are in a season of prolonged darkness with no resolution in sight, let this psalm assure you that such an experience does not put you outside the bounds of biblical faith—Scripture itself gives you these exact words. Resist the pressure to manufacture a hopeful ending to every prayer or conversation about your suffering; sometimes honest, unresolved lament is the most faithful thing you can offer God. Notice that the psalmist keeps crying out daily (v. 13) even without any sign of change—let that be your model when relief has not yet come.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

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Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. Have you ever felt pressure to resolve a lament with hope before you were actually ready, and how does this psalm's unresolved ending free you from that?

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2. Where are you currently 'stretching out your hands' to God daily (v. 9) without seeing any visible response, and how does this psalm validate continuing anyway?

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3. How does knowing Scripture includes an entirely unresolved prayer change how you might sit with someone else's unrelieved suffering?

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Name: \_\_\_\_\_ Date: \_\_\_\_\_ Group / Church: \_\_\_\_\_

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).